himself would act as head of the practice of Buddhism in his country. The monks would no longer debate the final interpretation of scriptures; instead, he himself, with Mahakassapa as his advisor, would decide on the correct ways of understanding the canonical laws. Together they would produce an official *katikavata*, a royal lawbook laying out exactly how Buddhism should be practiced; and this would have the same force as divine law.[8]

This marked an enormous departure from the past. Buddhist monarchs had always acted as the protectors and patrons of Buddhist monasteries, giving them grants of land and wealth, looking out for their survival. In Buddhist tradition, the monarch was both *cakravartin* (the king through whom *dharma*, all that is good and right, will spread across the universe) and *bodhisattva* (a manifestation of the Buddha himself, an enlightened one who had chosen to remain in the world in order to bring it salvation).

But Parakrama Bahu now claimed a much more pragmatic right. He removed many of the monks from the monasteries altogether and declared them laypeople. Then he ordered all ordinations to the Buddhist priesthood to take place in the capital city; that way, he could supervise them, and block any too-ambitious candidates from even entering the monasteries. And he himself would regulate their behavior.[9]

Divided and leaderless, the monastic orders could not resist the whirlwind reforms. Within the decade, Buddhist monasticism had been transformed into a powerful attractant force, inclined to pull the country together rather than throw it apart. And the practice of Buddhism itself had been made part of the framework of the new state: transformed, by its royal supervisor, into a secular force.

WHILE SRI LANKA coalesced into a single nation, the Chola empire was falling apart. For at least a thousand years, India had been a land of many minor kingdoms; for at least a thousand years, attempts to corral them into one fold had yielded temporary, illusory unity, followed by disintegration.

The enormous Chola realm of the twelfth century had been bordered, on the north and the east, by two related dynasties known as the Chalukya. The Eastern Chalukya had been conquered and forced into the empire two centuries before; their cousins, the Western Chalukya had been persuaded and bribed into alliance. But right around the time of Vijaya Bahu’s rebellion, the younger brother of the Western Chalukya king attacked his older sibling and took away his throne by force. Immediately, he broke the tradition of alliance and began to fight against the Chola instead.

A hundred years of warfare followed, and the constant drain of men and money opened gaps in the walls of both empires. A handful of vassals made